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Board of Education Report

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Mr. Schmerelson - Commemorating Diwali and Celebrating South Asian Heritage (Res-012-23/24) (For Action November 14, 2023)

Whereas, Diwali, also known as Deepawali, is a five-day festival observed by more than a billion people across faiths, including Hinduism, Sikhism, Newar, Buddhism, and Jainism;

Whereas, Diwali marks the start of the Hindu New Year: and symbolizes the spiritual victory of light over darkness, good over evil, and knowledge over ignorance;

Whereas, California has the largest Indian population in the United States, with nearly one million residents living within the state;

Whereas, Indian Americans contribute highly to California's economy, community, social services, and diverse culture;

Whereas, The Los Angeles Unified School District acknowledges the growing presence of Indian Americans and others of South Asian heritage in public life, service, and business positions;

Whereas, Diwali is celebrated as an official holiday in India, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Guyana, Fiji, Singapore, Trinidad and Tobago, Malaysia, and Mauritius; now therefore be it

Resolved, That the Governing Board of the Los Angeles Unified School District acknowledges Sunday, November 12, 2023, as Diwali;

Resolved further, That the District recognizes the importance of the South Asian Community, including Indian Americans, to Los Angeles and California as leaders for their contributions to their communities and various sectors such as, but not limited to, academics, health, science, and sports;

Resolved further, In alignment with the District's inclusive practices, the Governing Board of the Los Angeles Unified School District encourages the Superintendent to support and uplift the Indian American Community and others of South Asian heritage in our schools, workplaces, and communities; and, be it finally

Resolved, That the Board requests that the Superintendent update or create reference guides and resources to inform students, teachers and staff so that proper age appropriate discussions of Diwali can happen in our school sites and classrooms.